sardars. In fact he and his son Baji Rao I made the Peshwa the functional head of the Maratha empire.

Balaji Vishwanath took full advantage of the internal conflicts of the Mughal officials to increase Maratha power. He had induced Zulfiqar Khan to grant the *chauth* and *sardeshmukhi* of the Deccan. In the end, he signed a pact with the Saiyid brothers. All the territories that had earlier formed Shivaji's kingdom were restored to Shahu who was also assigned the *chauth* and *sardeshmukhi* of the six provinces of the Deccan. In return Shahu, who had already recognised, though nominally, Mughal suzerainty, agreed to place a body of 15,000 cavalry at the emperor's service, to prevent rebellion and plundering in the Deccan, and to pay an annual tribute of 10 lakhs of rupees. He also walked barefoot and paid obeisance at the tomb of Aurangzeb at Khuldabad in 1714. In 1719, Balaji Vishwanath, at the head of a Maratha force, accompanied Saiyid Hussain Ali Khan to Delhi and helped the Saiyid brothers in overthrowing Farrukh Siyar. At Delhi he and the other Maratha *sardars* witnessed at first hand the weakness of the empire and were filled with the ambition of expansion in the north.

For the efficient collection of the *chauth* and *sardeshmukhi* of the Deccan, Balaji Vishwanath assigned separate areas to Maratha *sardars* who kept the greater part of the collection for their expenses. This system of assignment of the *chauth* and *sardeshmukhi* also enabled the Peshwa to increase his personal power through patronage. An increasing number of ambitious *sardars* began to flock round him. In the long run this was to be a major source of weakness to the Maratha Empire. Already the system of *watans* and *saranjams* (jagirs) had made the Maratha *sardars* strong, autonomous, and jealous of central power. They now began to establish their control in the distant lands of the Mughal empire where they gradually settled down as more or less autonomous chiefs. Thus the conquests of the Marathas outside their original kingdom were not made by a central army directly controlled by the Maratha king or the Peshwa but by *sardars* with their own private armies. During the process of conquest these *sardars* often clashed with one another. If the central authority tried to control them too strictly,